to announce that a new feature has been delivered, or demonstrate how it works; they can look at the latest version of the living documentation and see for themselves.

12.3 Continuous delivery: any build is a potential release

Continuous delivery takes CI a step further. For a team that practices continuous delivery, any build is a potential release. To be deemed "release-ready," a particular version of an application must successfully pass through a number of *quality gateways*—unit tests, integration tests, acceptance tests, performance tests, code quality metrics, and so on. In continuous delivery, an executable version of the application is built and packaged very early on in the build process, and this same packaged version is passed through each of the quality gateways. This approach streamlines the process, because the application doesn't need to be rebuilt at each stage. If it successfully passes all of the gateways, it can be deployed to production if and when the business decides to do so.

An example of a build pipeline is illustrated in figure 12.5. Here, an initial build compiles the application and runs unit and integration tests. If these pass, a binary version of the application is prepared: this is the release candidate for this version.

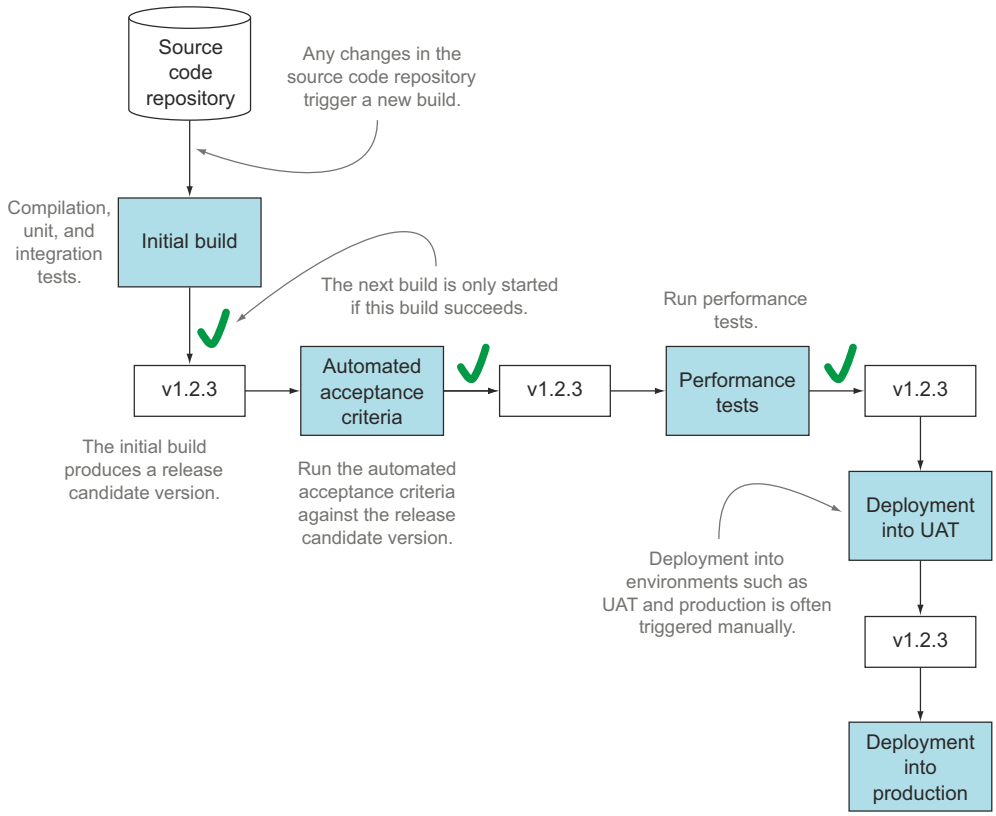


Figure 12.5 A simple build pipeline